

Session 10: Literary Design in Genesis 2:4-17

Key Takeaways

- Genesis 2:4-17 introduces the repeated biblical theme of God's chosen one being "rested" in the divine refuge.
- Like biblical poetry, biblical narrative repeats details, often with meaningful differences, to give multiple perspectives on the same reality. The biblical authors symbolically link humans, trees, and water repeatedly throughout Scripture.

Humanity is Created and Place in the Garden: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 2:4-17

4a These are the generations of the skies and the land,
when they were created:

The Waters

A 4b In the day when Yahweh made the land and skies,
5 **now**, no shrub of **the field** was yet in **the land**,
and no plant of **the field** had yet sprouted,
for the Lord God had not sent rain upon **the land**,
and there was no **human** to work the ground,
6 but **a stream/flow would go up** from **the land**
and it would water the whole face of the ground,

Humans in the Garden and the Tree of Life

B a 7 **and Yahweh God formed the human** of dust from the ground,
and he breathed into his nostrils the breath of life;
and the **human** became a living being.
b 8 And Yahweh God planted a **garden in Eden**, toward the east/from of old,
a' **and he placed there the the human whom he had formed**
b' 9 and Yahweh God caused to sprout from the **ground**
every tree that is desirable to sight and good for **eating**
and **the tree of life** also in the **middle of the garden**.

and **the tree of** **the knowledge of good and bad**.

The Waters

10 **Now**, **a river went out** from Eden **to water** the garden,
and from there it separated and became four heads:

a 11 **The name of the** **first** is Pishon;

b it goes around the whole **land** of Havilah,
which has there gold

12 and the gold of that **land** is good;

there are the bdellium and the onyx stone.

a' 13 **And the name of the** **second** river is Gihon;

b' it goes around the whole land of Cush.

a' 14 **And the name of the** **third** river is Tigris;

b' it goes east of Assyria.

a' **And the** **fourth** river,

b' it is the Euphrates.

Humans in the Garden and the Tree of Death

15 **And Yahweh God took the** **human**

and he rested him in the **garden in Eden** to work (עבד • 'avad) and to keep (שמר • shamar) it.

16 And Yahweh God commanded the **human** saying,

a " **From every tree of the garden**

b **you may surely eat**

a 17 but from **tree of** **the knowledge of good and bad**

b **you shall not eat from it**,

a for in the day that **you eat from it**,

b you will surely **die**."

Genesis 2:4-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Observations on the Macro Design of Genesis 2:4-17

Pattern: The Waters

This symmetrical design invites the reader to compare the pre-garden waters (A) with the garden waters (A'). The stream/flow by itself does not create Eden in 2:4b-6, but it does create the clay and generates potential for Eden to exist. For Eden to emerge, God must direct the waters toward a purpose and then plant a garden (B), which then (B') creates an overflow of value for the nations (Israel, Egypt, Mesopotamia, Assyria).

Translation Comparison for "Stream" (2:6)

- NIV: “But **streams** came up from the earth and watered the whole surface of the ground.”
- ESV: “And a **mist** was going up from the land and was watering the whole face of the ground—”
- NASB: “But a **mist** used to rise from the earth and water the whole surface of the ground.”
- NRSV: “But a **stream** would rise from the earth, and water the whole face of the ground—”
- NLT: “Instead, **springs** came up from the ground and watered all the land.”
- KJV: “But there went up a **mist** from the earth, and watered the whole face of the ground.”

Pattern: Humans Put in the Garden

The double placing (B and B') of humanity in the garden is intentional. The first placement in 2:7-9 and 2:10-14 is about God setting humanity in a cultivated environment which is ripe with potential. The second placement in 2:15-17 focuses on the test that the garden represents.

- 2:15: “And he rested him” (וינחהו) points forward to the story of Noah (נח), who will have to bring comfort (Gen. 5:29 [נחם]) to the land that is cursed because of humanity’s folly in the garden by offering a sacrifice on top of the sacred mountain. This comparison invites the reader to see how God is placing this human atop a sacred mountain of Eden in this story as well. It also hints forward to Noah’s own failure in his garden-vineyard (Gen. 9:20-24).
- 2:16: The divine command to eat from all trees except for one sets up the plot tension of the test.

“Rest” in the Hebrew Bible

The use of the verb “rest” continues throughout the Bible.

- Joshua 11:23, 23:1: Joshua gives the people rest in the promised land.
- 2 Samuel 7:1: David, God’s appointed representative, is given rest and placed on Mount Zion.
- 1 Kings 5:4-5: Solomon sees that there is rest in the land and decides to build the temple.

This is a common strategy used by biblical authors—intentional repetition with small differences. The second time, they can use a different verb in order to lay the groundwork for an important pattern. In this case, it is the pattern of God’s appointed one being rested in the divine refuge.

Pattern: Trees

Notice that the first introduction of the trees in (B) emphasizes the tree of life, while the introduction of the divine command (B') emphasizes the tree that could bring death.

Hebrew Wordplays with “From the Ground”

Notice the coordination of water/humans/plants by their common origins “from the ground.”

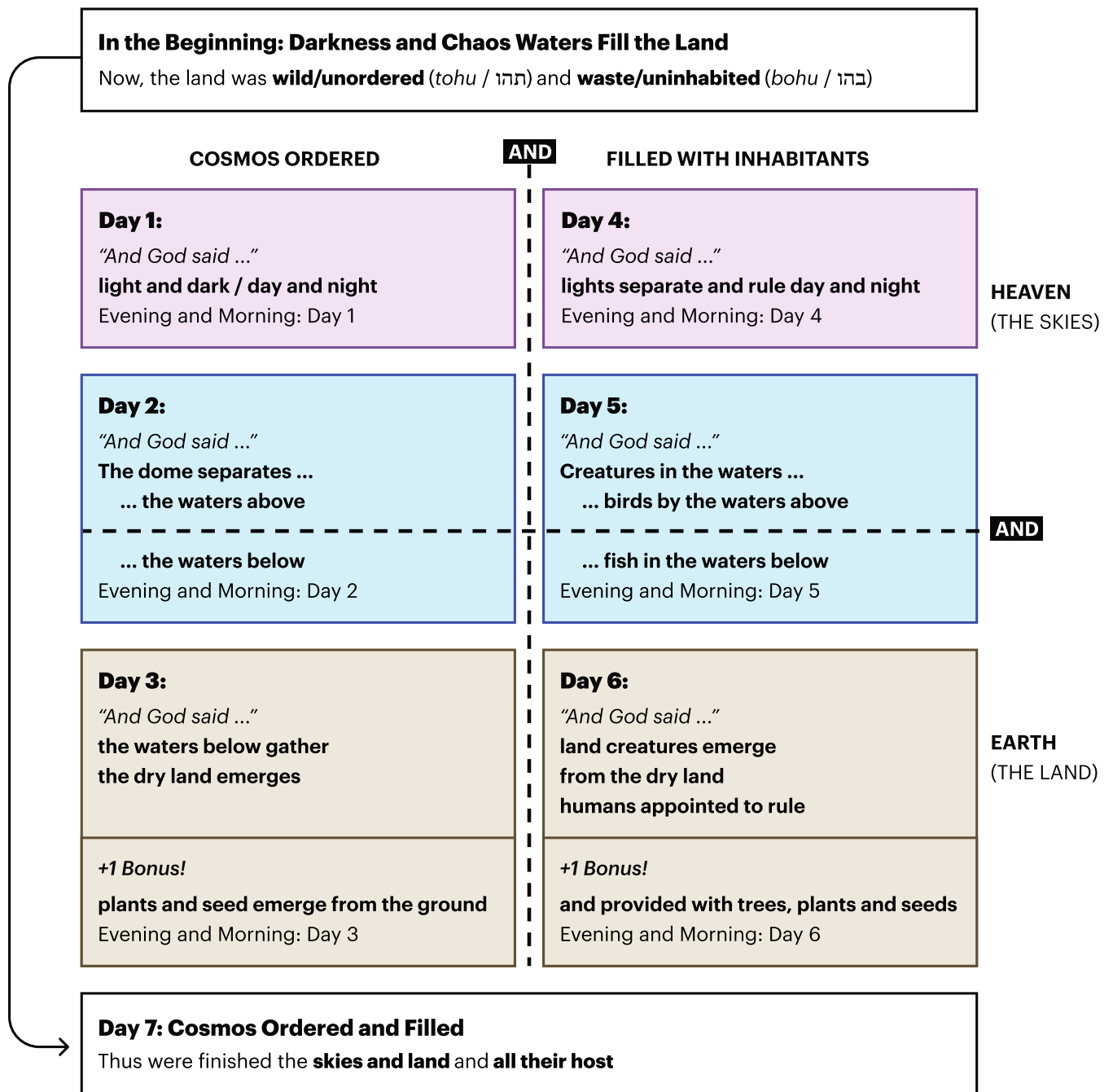
- Genesis 2:5: No human (אדם) to work the ground (אדמה)
- Genesis 2:6: A spring (אד) would go up from the land (מן הארץ) to water the ground (אדמה)
- Genesis 2:7: Yahweh formed (וייצר) human (אדם) as dust from the ground (מן האדמה)
- Genesis 2:9: And Yahweh sprouted (ויצמח) from the ground (מן האדמה) every tree

Humans, Waters, and Trees

The water is a gift of divine life that makes two types of derivative life possible, and both bear fruit in the land. Humans bear fruit through what they do, and trees bear fruit through what they grow. They are like each other. In the biblical imagination, people are like trees, and both have their life source rooted in water.

Comparison of Days Three and Six in Genesis 1

Days one through three of creation are parallel to days four through six in Genesis 1. Notice the comparison between day three and six. On day three, the trees produce fruit. On day six, the humans produce fruit.



Origami of Genesis 1. Adapted from David Andrew Teeter by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Reflection Question

What are the three things that come up from the dirt in Genesis 2:4-17?